

The Puranas are 18 major canonical texts (Mahapuranas) in Hinduism that preserve ancient mythology, cosmology, genealogy, and spiritual teachings, serving as the bridge between abstract Vedic philosophy and everyday life. They are traditionally divided into three categories based on the three fundamental qualities of nature: Sattva (Goodness), Rajas (Passion), and Tamas (Ignorance).

The 18 Major Puranas (Mahapuranas)

1. Sattvic Puranas (Glorifying Lord Vishnu)

- **Vishnu Purana:** Explains the cosmic creation, genealogies of kings, and chronicles the life and avatars of Lord Vishnu.
- **Bhagavata Purana:** The most popular Purana; focuses heavily on deep devotion (Bhakti), detailing the lives of various avatars, with a profound focus on the pastimes of Lord Krishna.
- **Naradiya Purana:** Contains a synopsis of all Puranas, descriptions of major holy sites (like Jagannatha Puri), and discussions on duties and liberation.
- **Garuda Purana:** Primarily dedicated to Lord Vishnu, it is famously known for its guidance regarding death, the afterlife, and funeral rites.
- **Padma Purana:** Contains extensive legends about the lotus (Padma), creation, and the importance of various holy rivers, as well as the greatness of the Bhagavad Gita.
- **Varaha Purana:** Narrated by Lord Varaha (the boar incarnation of Vishnu), it covers cosmic geography, religious vows, and salvation.

2. Rajasic Puranas (Glorifying Lord Brahma)

- **Brahmanda Purana:** Contains the *Lalita Sahasranamam*, which extols the glory of Goddess Parvati, as well as early astronomical and geographic concepts.
- **Brahmavaivarta Purana:** Explores the creation of the universe and focuses on the divine, romanticized devotion of Radha and Krishna.
- **Markandeya Purana:** Narrated by Sage Markandeya to Sage Jaimini, it contains the *Devi Mahatmya* (Chandi), a key text in Shakta traditions.
- **Bhavishya Purana:** Focuses on the future, containing mythological prophecies about future dynasties and social structures.
- **Vamana Purana:** Dedicated to the Vamana (dwarf) avatar of Vishnu, it features tales that seamlessly praise both Vishnu and Shiva.
- **Brahma Purana:** Also known as the *Adi Purana*, it is an overview of the universe, the Sun God, and various places of pilgrimage.

3. Tamasic Puranas (Glorifying Lord Shiva)

- **Shiva Purana:** Dedicated entirely to Lord Shiva, it describes his manifestations, the creation of the universe, and the paths to achieving spiritual liberation.
- **Linga Purana:** Explains the origin and philosophical significance of the Lingam, which represents the iconic and formless attributes of Shiva.
- **Skanda Purana:** The longest Purana; it details the legends of Skanda (Kartikeya) and extensively maps the geography, temples, and history of various Indian pilgrimage sites.
- **Matsya Purana:** Narrated by the Matsya (fish) avatar of Vishnu, it covers temple architecture, politics, and the cosmic cycles of time.
- **Kurma Purana:** Narrated by the Kurma (turtle) avatar of Vishnu, it explores the philosophical synthesis between Vaishnava, Shaiva, and Shakta traditions.
- **Agni Purana:** Narrated by Lord Agni, this text acts as an ancient encyclopedia. It covers martial arts, medicine, *Vastu Shastra* (architecture), grammar, and warfare.

Importance of the Puranas

The Puranas shape much of modern Hindu practice and worldview through several critical functions:

- **Encyclopaedic Knowledge:** They act as storehouses for ancient Indian history, sociology, politics, medicine, astronomy, and temple construction.
- **Accessible Spirituality:** While the Vedas are strict and primarily for scholars, the Puranas translate profound Vedic philosophies into relatable stories, moral lessons, and everyday practices.
- **Dharma and Ethics:** They define righteous living (Dharma) and provide models of ideal conduct through the tales of heroic kings, sages, and avatars.
- **Bhakti Movement:** By humanizing gods and demonstrating that salvation is achievable through loving devotion (Bhakti), the Puranas helped fuel the widespread Bhakti movement across India.
- **Cosmology:** They outline the Hindu concept of time, detailing the cyclical creation, preservation, and dissolution of the universe.